

HOUSEPLANTS AND MENTAL WELL-BEING

I lecture all the time on the benefits of outdoor gardening to our mental health, but many would be surprised by just how good indoor gardening is, too—especially as we are spending more of our time indoors, with some people not having access to their own outside space.

I believe that indoor plants can make a practical and emotional contribution to our well-being. Our ever-changing urban modern societies, alongside ever-advancing technological developments, exert a constant pressure on humans to “keep up” with this fast-paced life. This pressure can trigger stress, low moods, low motivation,

and low self-esteem as well as contribute to record levels of depression, PTSD, anxiety, loneliness, and OCD.

Caring for houseplants offers an enjoyable experience that can help in recovery. The appreciation of nature runs deep in our evolutionary makeup. For our hunter-gatherer ancestors, the bright colors of flowers signaled nutrition and a food source, triggering the “happy” hormone dopamine in the brain at the prospect of a reward. Even now, when we have food all year round, the blossoming of flowers still induces that same feel-good chemical, while becoming absorbed in caring for plants can provide a calming focus to help the mind recuperate.

Focus & memory

The joy of seeing plants in flower or being fascinated by foliage can create positive distractions and spark happy memories.

- **Happy distractions** Being responsible for a living thing can break the cycle of negative thought patterns and replace them with positive ones, taking your focus away from your stresses and toward new life.



King begonias

Begonias fascinate with their intricate leaf patterns



Tiger aloe

Aloes surprise with unusual blooms

Natural features

Intriguing begonias (see pp.46–47) and aloes (see pp.40–41) provide positive distractions and improve focus.